

August Shivers

As I shiver in the bleary parking lot, my phone became that of a vibrator.
Friends would not stop and listen to my angle, instead it was a matter of
Me bending or breaking. This is why I go great lengths and distances to
Usually spend my birthday elsewhere, great lengths and distances away.

While I shook through the onslaught of mindless suggestion, I knew that
My father was just 45 minutes north, alone, with nothing but some Hero
Bread and preseason football. His neck permanent at a 45° angle as he
Lies crowded by clothing multiple sizes smaller than he has been in years.

He keeps them as “motivation” and so he won’t have to buy new ones.
Meanwhile he chokes down even more calories once he eventually has the
Tiniest of breaks. Matted carpet that hasn’t been vacuumed in 3 and a half
Years, and the shoe hanger flopping against his door whenever you open.

Industrial wire shelving furnished with ancient dishes coated in sauce
Claim most of the space. A whole AC unit roars while rattling beside
his bed with the tubing awkwardly duct taped up to the window where
Black Widows find their way through, dangling above when you wake.

A hole the size of two basketballs has been punched through the drywall
Just next to his bed and childishly covered with black Gorilla tape, there
To tell us of the times he lost in Call of Duty, and a 45” TV in the middle
Of it all is used every day while still collecting dust, illuminating grime.

Two separate two-liter bottles of urine sit right above his head touching
Against the four separate bottles of salad dressing that he drinks as he
Sinks into football or Ice Road Truckers. The bright white boob light

Never stops stinging against the yellow walls and dusty sticky surfaces.

In the summer months he and his flip-flops will venture out and up the canyon on his beloved motorcycle, spending whole days away from the Dungeon, allowing him to watch the same pointless football from his Hammock. These are never done with Melissa, only on his lonesome.

This friend of mine, the one voted “Most Likely to be a Millionaire,” has Only me for a son, and at seven o’clock has still not wished happy birthday. This is not why I hate it; it’s never been fun. But now I will go rattle and bloom In an algae green hot tub with a few colleagues while my father stays put in my

Mind no matter how hard I shake and I rattle and I shiver.